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Introduction

The most frequently observed biological impact of climate change is major changes in phenology—the timing of recurring life history events. For trees, shifts in spring and autumn phenology modify when the seasons start and end. In the northern hemisphere, spring events have advanced, and autumn have delayed, but to a much lesser extent. Together, early springs and later autumns should increase tree growth.

The positive relationship between growing season length and tree growth is crucial for climate forecasting. With anthropogenic climate change that will keep affecting biological processes worldwide, increasing the accuracy of carbon cycle models is crucial. Indeed, among the many processes that are included in these models, carbon sequestration by forests is an important one. In particular, temperate forests contribute offset a large part of human-emitted greenhouse gas emissions. However, this relies on the positive relationship between growing season length and tree growth. If this relationship changes, current and future climate solutions could be impacted.

Recent evidence suggests that longer growing seasons did not increase growth. Indeed, *Dow showed at a local scale that longer growing season did not increase growth. Additionally, *Cabon found a similar trend where different biomes gross primary production (GPP) and growth were decoupled at the global scale. Understanding these findings requires answering why trees do not grow more despite longer growing seasons.

Longer growing seasons do not necessarily mean more favorable conditions for growth throughout the season. Longer seasons are not necessarily warmer. In addition, the well-documented advancement of spring phenology increases the growing season length, but does not increase growing degree days (GDD) by that much (Figure 1). In addition, while trees have a longer period to grow, water availability may not be sufficient to support continuous growth throughout the growing season. Finally, while intra and inter-specific competition has no relationship with climate change, the extra days trees get in the season may be offset by competition for light, which juvenile trees are especially vulnerable to.

Different plant organs (e.g. leaves vs wood) differ in their plasticity. Leaf phenology is a highly plastic trait, supported by decades of research on the relationship between warming spring and leaf phenology. However, we know a lot less about the plasticity of growth in response to temperature and duration of growth. In deciduous trees diffuse-porous trees, leaf phenology and growth are closely synchronized. However, this does not indicate anything about how much trees grow in a year.

Local adaptation could inform tree growth responses with future climate change. Trees from northern provenances will likely grow less with longer seasons, because they adapted for shorter seasons and therefore have a shorter window of opportunity, despite potentially better conditions for a longer period. Between the start and end of season, budset (EOS) is much more locally adapted than leafout, which indicates that the end of season may actually be the most constraining factors affecting trees across a latitudinal gradient. Thus, common gardens investigating the effect of provenance latitude are really important to better understand how climate change will affect tree growth.

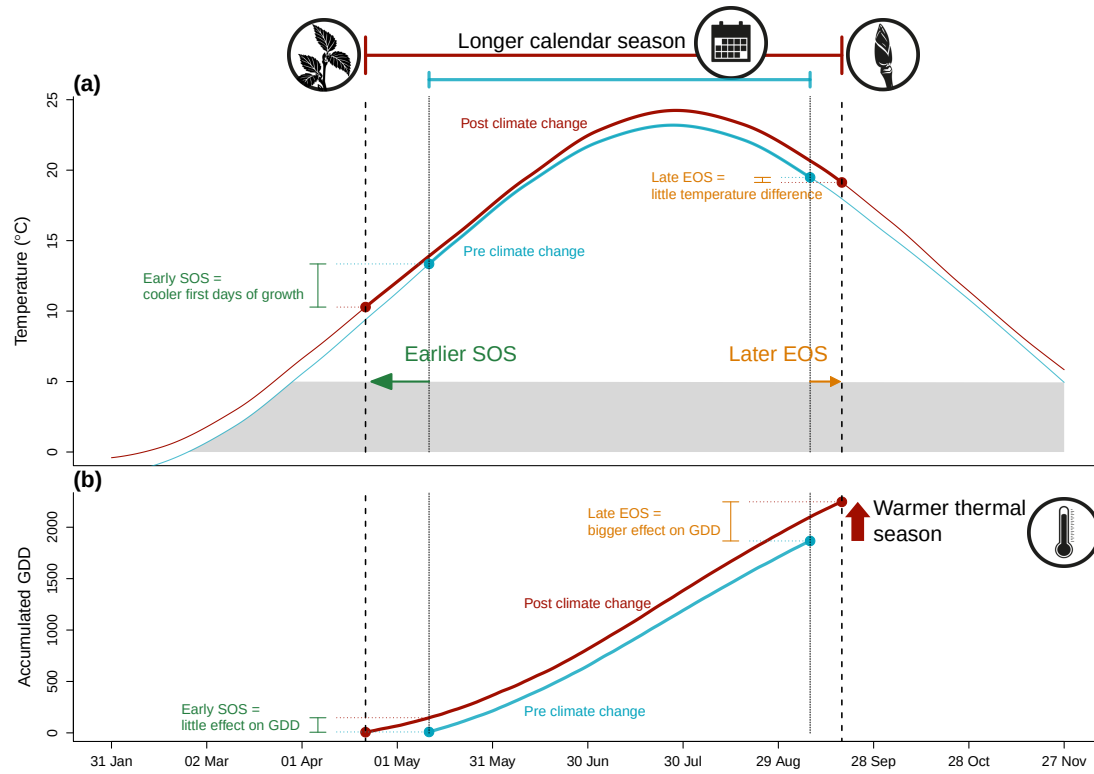


Figure 1: We show how shifting growing season length with climate change affects both the temperature trees experience throughout the growing season (a), and how much growing degree days (GDD) they accumulate (b). We used mean daily temperature data from the Boston airport Climate station for the smoothed temperature and GDD curves. We represent the changes in temperature before (1945-1965 in blue) and after the 1980s increase in climate warming (2005-2025 in red). With climate change, spring events (green arrow) have advanced and fall phenology (orange arrow) has delayed, but to much lesser extent (day advancements are fake and represented by the arrows), this lengthened the calendar growing season, but concurrently changed the temperature trees experience early in their season. Growth onset earlier in the season means the first days of growth are cooler (a) resulting in little accumulation of GDD (b). Though shifts in EOS are weaker and the temperature experienced changed little (a), the GDD accumulation rate late in the season is higher than early in the season. Alongside warmer summer temperature, this results in higher GDD accumulation, warming their thermal seasons.

Methods

Common garden setup and data collection

We collected seeds from 18 species of deciduous trees and shrubs from four provenances across a 3.5° latitudinal gradient (Figure 2 and Table S1) in 2014-2015, germinated them following standard germination protocols and grew them to seedlings (Baskin & Baskin, 2014). In the spring of 2017, we planted the seedlings outside at the Weld Hill Research Building at the Arnold Arboretum in Boston MA (42.30°N, 71.13°W). Plots were regularly weeded and watered throughout the duration of the study and were pruned in the fall of 2020 (Buonaiuto, unpublished).

For the years 2018-2020, we monitored leaf phenology for all individuals in the common garden once or twice per week from February to December; the exact frequency varied within and across years (for more details see Figure S1). For this, we used a modified BBCH scale to observe two phenological stages: leafout which

we defined as: BBCH 15 and budset as BBCH 102; (Finn *et al.*, 2007); Buonuito, unpublished). We had a total of 239 leafout and 230 budset observations (which we refer to as the ‘full datasets’), but for some individual trees in certain years we did not have both events, thus our total of matched full growing season durations (which we refer to as the ‘restricted dataset’) is 227.

In the spring of 2023, we collected tree ring samples from tree species with high survivorship. Thus, we have four species in the *Betulaceae* family : Grey alder (*Alnus incana*), Yellow birch (*Betula alleghaniensis*), Paper birch (*Betula papyrifera*) and Grey birch (*Betula populifolia*). We collected cross-sections on 78 individuals by cutting the trunk above the root collar, and cores on 43 individuals using standard dendrochronological methods (Cook & Kairiukstis, 1990), for a total of 81 individual trees (Table S1). We stored the cores in modified plastic straws to allow aeration and left them to dry with the cross-sections at ambient temperature for three months.

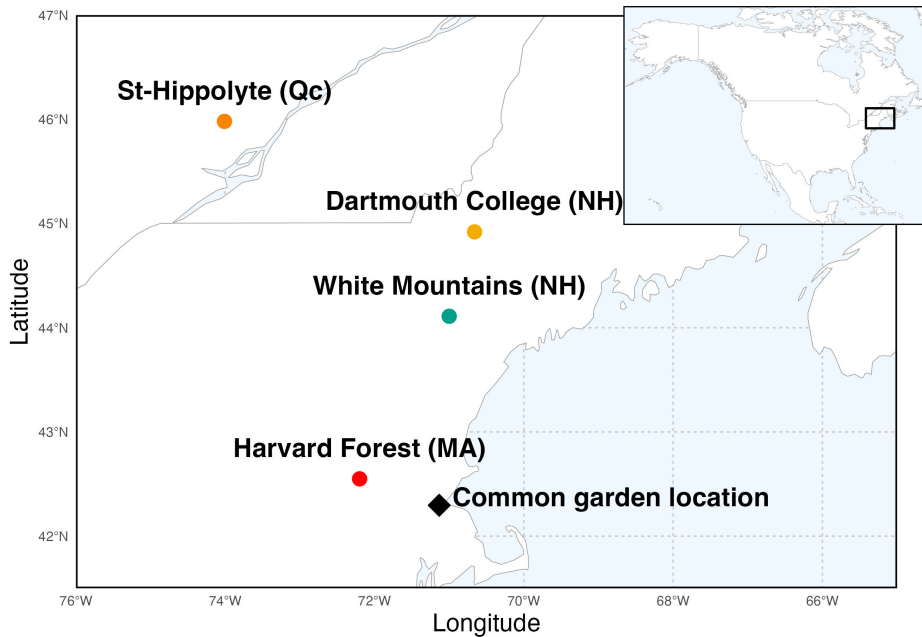


Figure 2: Provenance where the seeds were sourced from are depicted as circles, while the diamond denotes the location of the common garden. The common garden location is where the study took place at the Weld Research Building (Boston, MA). The colors of the dots match the model estimates of Figure 4.

Sample processing, imaging and measuring

We mounted cores on wooden mounts, and sanded both the cores and cross-sections using progressively finer sandpaper grits (150, 300, 400, 600, 800, 1000), then scanned the cores and cross-sections at a resolution of 6250 dpi with a high-resolution treering scanner (Fong, unpublished). Using the digitized images, we measured ring widths with ImageJ (Schneider *et al.*, 2012) at three standard locations for each cross-section (at 120° from each other, averaging the three measurements to yield one ring width per year, per individual), and one ring width for each core. When we had cross-sections ($n = 78$) and cores ($n = 43$) for an individual, we used only the measurement from the cross sections ($n = 81$).

We performed visual cross dating. This consists of assigning a calendar year to each ring and compare the year-to-year growth variation and anomalies across replicates of the same species (Cook & Kairiukstis, 1990). We did not perform statistical crossdating or detrending because our chronologies (years of data) were extremely short (Raden *et al.*, 2020) and showed no evidence of consistent allometric trends (Figure

S2). We controlled for effects of different years by including year in our models (see ‘Data analyses’ below)

Data analyses

To understand how growth shifted with season lengths we used linear Bayesian hierarchical models, estimating how growth, measured as ring width, covaried with season length, measured in four different season ways: GDD, GSL, SOS and EOS. We calculated the thermal season using growing degree days (GDD; mean daily temperature above 5°C) accumulated between leafout and budset, and the calendar season (or growing season length; GSL) as the number of days between leafout and budset. Finally, we used leafout as the start (SOS) and budset end of the season (EOS) as separate predictors that represent the boundaries of the growing season. For interpretability, we report ring width change ($\log(\text{mm})$) as the number of GDDs accumulated in an average week (seven days) in May (day of year 121 to 150 from 2018 to 2020), for the thermal season, and ring width change per week of season length, leafout and budset for GSL, SOS and EOS, respectively. We report effects when the 90% UI do not overlap with zero and consider a trend if the 50% UI do not overlap with zero.

For daily climate data across all the years of phenological sampling (2018-2020) we combined two sources. For 2018 and 2019 we used data from the climate station located at Weld Hill research station (Arnold Arboretum, 2026). Because the data was not available for that station after August 2020, we used data from the weather station “Boston (Weld Hill)” of the Network for Environment and Weather Applications (NEWA) for the whole year in 2020 (Carroll *et al.*, 2026). We used the North American Drought Monitor Maps to determine drought occurrence across year at our study location and used the proposed drought intensity to qualify presence of moderate, severe or extreme droughts (National Centers for Environmental Information (NCEI), 2026)

For each predictor, we estimated its effect on ring width observed (i , denoting each observation) for each tree ($treeid$) in each year ($year$) as:

$$\begin{aligned} \ln(ringwidth)_i &\sim N(\mu, \sigma_y) \\ \mu &= \alpha + \alpha_{species} + \alpha_{prov} + \alpha_{treeid} + \alpha_{year} + \beta_{species} \times \text{season predictor} \\ \alpha_{prov} &\sim N(0, \sigma_{\alpha_{prov}}) \\ \alpha_{treeid} &\sim N(0, \sigma_{\alpha_{treeid}}) \end{aligned}$$

This model estimates a species-specific effect of each season length predictor (e.g. GDD) on growth ($\beta_{species}$), while also controlling for other variation due to species ($\alpha_{species}$), provenance (α_{prov}), individual tree (α_{treeid}) and year (α_{year}). We ran the models using both natural units and scaled predictors through z -scoring (Gelman & Hill, 2006) to allow for direct effect size comparison. We report estimates as means and 90% uncertainty intervals (UI).

We used weakly informative priors for all models (increasing the priors by 2X for the z -scored models did not qualitatively affect the results). We ran four chains with 2000 warmup and 2000 sampling iterations each, for a total of 8000 sampling iterations and checked diagnostics of output: chains had no divergent transitions, $\hat{R}$ values below 1.01, and effective sample sizes (n_{eff}) greater than 10% of the model iterations. We wrote our models using Stan (Carpenter *et al.*, 2017) with the rstan package version 2.32.7 (Stan Development Team, 2025) to run the Stan code in R.

Because ring widths decrease with age—particularly with young trees—we also ran the models using basal area increment (BAI) as the response variable. This allows for a more representative portrayal of annual growth increment by using the total ring area, instead of its width alone. For this, we summed each ring width separately at the three distinct locations on the cross sections yielding three radii from pit to bark. We then calculated the area of each ring by subtracting the radius from the inner ring from the outer ring: $\pi \times (\text{Inner radius}^2 - \text{Outer radius}^2)$, and averaged across the three BAI for each ring. Finally, we also fit

the models for SOS and EOS using both the restricted ($n = 227$) and full datasets for each predictor (SOS $n = 239$ and EOS $n = 230$).

Results

Our dataset comprised four deciduous tree species from four sites with leaf phenology data spanning three years (2018 to 2020) for a total of 239 leafout and 230 budset observations, yielding 227 complete growing seasons (GS) for 81 individuals. At the common garden location, the mean summer temperature was similar across years with 2019 being the coolest (22.38°C), 2020 the hottest (23.07°C), and 2018 in between (22.85°C). There was no drought for those three years, except for in 2020, where a moderate summer drought (June, July and August) ramped up to a severe drought in September (National Centers for Environmental Information (NCEI), 2026). The calendar and thermal seasons ranged from 90 days and 1465.1 GDD (*B. alleghaniensis* in 2018) to 173 days and 2513.6 GDD (*A. incana* in 2018) (Figure S8a and b). The earliest leafout was 22-Apr (*A. incana* in 2019) and the latest, 05-Jun (also *A. incana*, but in 2020) (Figure S8c). The earliest budset was 13-Aug (*B. alleghaniensis* in 2018) and the latest, 24-Oct (*A. incana* in 2018) (Figure S8d). Finally, annual ring widths across years varied from 0.39 mm (*B. alleghaniensis* in 2020) to 13.55 mm (*B. populifolia* in 2018; Figure S7).

Longer growing seasons increased growth for all species, but varied depending on the metric used to measure it. We report estimates as means and 90% uncertainty intervals (UI) that correspond to ring width change in mm on the log scale—henceforth ‘ Δ RW/scaled predictor’ (see ‘Data analyses’ section in Methods for more details on predictor scaling). Warmer thermal seasons increased growth for Paper birch (*Betula papyrifera*; $\beta = 0.15$, UI: 0.06, 0.23 Δ RW/scaled GDD), Grey birch (*Betula populifolia*; $\beta = 0.07$, UI: 0.02, 0.12 Δ RW/scaled GDD), and Yellow birch (*Betula alleghaniensis*; $\beta = 0.04$, UI: 0, 0.08 Δ RW/scaled GDD), grey alder (*Alnus incana*) trended in the same direction ($\beta = 0.02$, UI: -0.01, 0.05 Δ RW/scaled GDD); Figure 3a and e; Table S2). Unlike its response to warmer thermal season, *A. incana* grew more with longer calendar seasons ($\beta = 0.05$, UI: 0, 0.1 Δ RW/scaled GSL). *B. papyrifera* also grew more with longer calendar seasons ($\beta = 0.18$, UI: 0.06, 0.31 Δ RW/scaled GSL), while the other two *Betula* did not, though they trended in the same way (*B. alleghaniensis*: $\beta = 0.03$, UI: -0.03, 0.09 Δ RW/scaled GSL, and *B. populifolia*: $\beta = 0.06$, UI: -0.02, 0.13 Δ RW/scaled GSL; Figure 3b and f; Table S2). On a scaled axis (through z -scoring (Gelman & Hill, 2006)), the thermal and calendar season were similarly predictive (Figure S9). Additionally, the results with basal area increment (BAI) for the GDD model were broadly similar to ring width (see Table S5).

Increased growth with longer seasons is often presumed to come from growth in the spring, since spring phenology has shifted much more than fall phenology. In contrast to this expectation, we found most species grew more with a later end of season, and only one species grew more with an earlier start of season (*A. incana* (one of the two species that a longer calendar season increased growth for) $\beta = -0.07$, UI: -0.14, -0.01 Δ RW/scaled SOS; Figure 3c and g; Table S2). *B. alleghaniensis* which did not grow more with longer calendar season, grew less with an earlier start of season ($\beta = 0.1$, UI: 0, 0.2 Δ RW/scaled SOS; Figure 3c and g; Table S2)—but more with a later end of season ($\beta = 0.12$, UI: 0.05, 0.18 Δ RW/scaled EOS). Alongside *B. alleghaniensis*, two other species grew more with a later end of season (*B. populifolia*: $\beta = 0.1$, UI: 0.02, 0.17 Δ RW/scaled EOS, and *B. papyrifera*: $\beta = 0.21$, UI: 0.09, 0.33 Δ RW/scaled EOS; Figure 3d and h; Table S2), with the latter being the only one of those three that also grew more with longer calendar season. The estimates were unchanged when using the full (SOS: $n = 239$ and EOS: $n = 230$) or restricted datasets ($n = 227$; Figure S3a).

We did not find any clear effect of year on growth (2018: $\alpha = 0.18$, UI: -0.76, 1.1 RW; 2019: $\alpha = 0.16$, UI: -0.78, 1.08 RW; 2020: $\alpha = -0.45$, UI: -1.38, 0.48 RW; Table S4), and there were no apparent differences on baseline growth between species (*A. incana*: $\alpha = 1$, UI: -3.08, 5.07 RW; *B. alleghaniensis*: $\alpha = 0.15$, UI: -3.97, 4.24 RW; *B. papyrifera*: $\alpha = -4.04$, UI: -8.95, 0.81 RW; *B. populifolia*: $\alpha = -0.71$, UI: -4.93, 3.38 RW; Figure S4 and S5; Table S4). In addition, growth did not vary with provenance (Dartmouth College (NH): $\alpha = -0.03$, UI: -0.23, 0.16 RW; Harvard Forest (MA): $\alpha = -0.1$, UI: -0.33, 0.07 RW; St-Hippolyte (Qc): $\alpha = 0.04$, UI: -0.15, 0.26 RW; White Mountains (NH): $\alpha = 0.08$, UI: -0.09, 0.3 RW; Figure 4; Table S3).

The limited variation between provenances ($\sigma = 0.17$, UI: 0.02, 0.47 RW) was similar to variation across individual trees ($\sigma = 0.17$, UI: 0.04, 0.27 RW; Table S4).

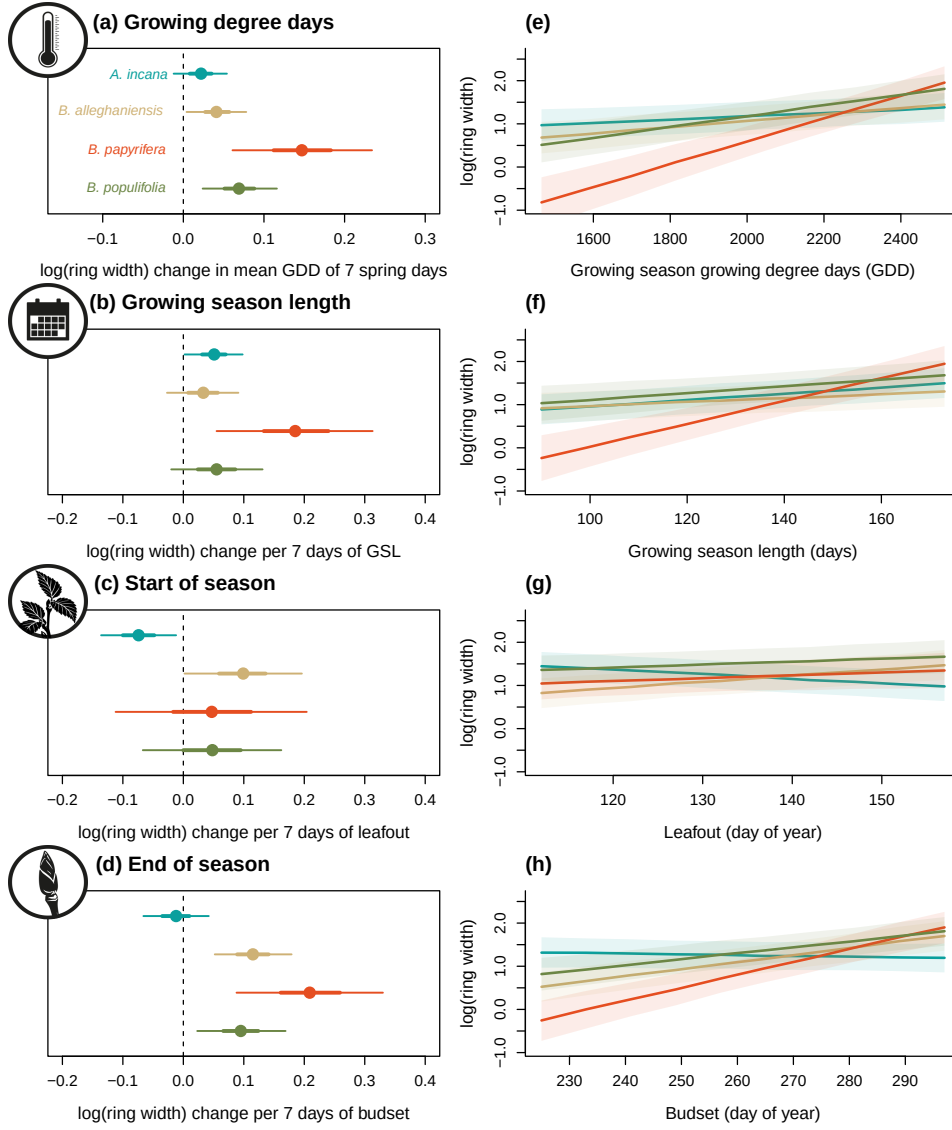


Figure 3: Estimates of ring width change ($\log(\text{mm})$) as a function of four different phenological predictors: growing degree days of the growing season, GDD (mean daily temperature above 5°C); growing season length, GSL; start of season (SOS); end of season (EOS) across four species (Grey alder (*Alnus incana*), Yellow birch (*Betula alleghaniensis*), Paper birch (*Betula papyrifera*) and Grey birch (*Betula populifolia*; species colors are the same across the panels). Panels (a) to (d) represent the model slope estimates for each species, for each predictor, which we represent through $\Delta \text{RW}/\text{scaled predictor}$ (see ‘Data analyses’ section in Methods for more details on predictor scaling). The dots represent the mean of each species and the lines, the 50% and 90% uncertainty intervals (UI). See Table S2 for parameter estimates. Panels (e) to (h) represent the simulated response curves of ring width as a function of each predictor, with the lines depicting the mean response at each simulated predictor value, and the shaded area, the interquartile ranges (50% UI)

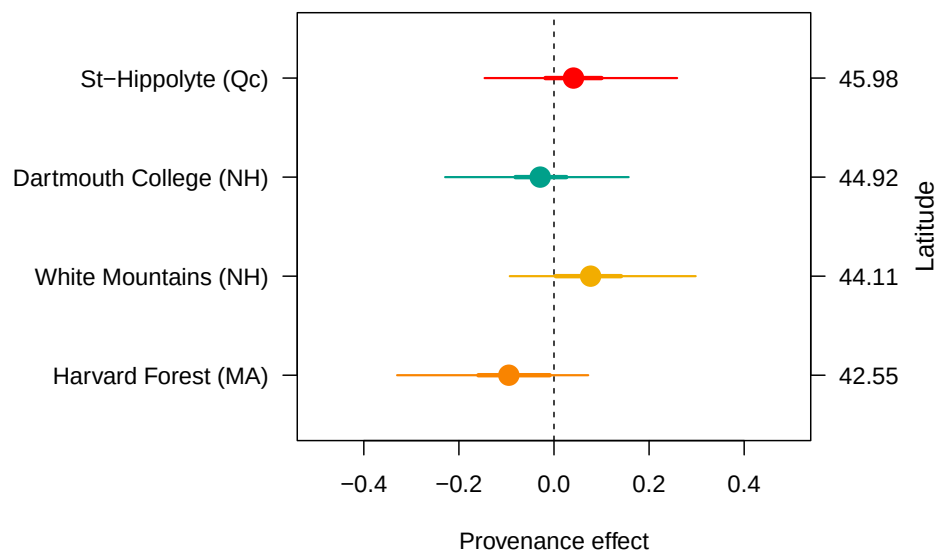


Figure 4: The effect of provenance on growth across a latitudinal gradient. We show the ring width (log(mm)) (see Table S4 for grand mean estimate) for each provenance with growing degree days (GDD) as the predictor (effects were similar for the other predictors, see Table S3). The dots represent the mean of each provenance and the thick lines, the 50% and 90% uncertainty intervals (UI). The provenances are color-coded from Figure 2, the map showing their locations.

Discussion

Here we used 81 juvenile trees of four species from four provenances to answer if longer growing seasons increased tree growth. For this, we used annual growth via tree rings and leaf phenology as a proxy for the start (SOS) and end of season (EOS). We found that the thermal season (GDD) was a better predictor for growth than the calendar season (GSL) and that provenance weakly impacted growth.

The thermal season better predicts growth than the calendar season

The thermal season is a better predictor for growth because it is more closely aligned to when, but also how fast trees grow. Indeed, by accounting for the temperature throughout the year, the thermal season weighs growing days better than the calendar season which assumes a constant importance of each day. For instance, the short and cool spring days early in the season count for less for the thermal season vs the calendar season (Figure 1)—which our results reflect by showing a stronger response to the thermal season. Coherently, our results demonstrate a stronger response of the end of season than SOS, because the temperature late in the season is warmer than early in the season, so the GDD accumulation is higher. Thus, any extra days late in the season has a bigger importance than any extra days early in the season.

We can use the start and end of season to disentangle the calendar season effect on growth. Our findings showed that an early SOS did not increase growth for most species, which is aligned with previous studies (e.g. *Dow). Most of our species grew more with a later EOS which furthermore relates to the thermal than the calendar season. As a result, studies that solely focus on SOS might miss that longer seasons lead to more growth.

Future growth trends in response to soil moisture during the growing season is unclear. A later EOS when coupled with appropriate soil moisture leads to increased growth, as we and other studies have found. There are currently no increases in droughts within our species range, suggesting that drought should increase. However, the positive trend of a later EOS could be offset if soil moisture becomes inadequate. While during our study, the driest period was late in the season (2020), this is not a current observed trend throughout the northeaster US. If that changes with future climate change, growth could decline in response to decreased soil moisture—a pattern observed in other regions.

Contrasting growth responses across species, but not across provenances

Our four species did not respond symmetrically to the different season predictors. Indeed, *A. incana* grew more with a longer calendar season and an earlier SOS, suggesting that most of that species' growth happens in the spring. *A. incana* is a ruderal and species that share this life-history strategy allows them to be very flexible in response to changing conditions and might provide them the opportunity of growing most early in the spring when days are shorter and cooler. In contrast, *B. papyrifera* and *B. populifolia* appeared to be most driven by the EOS, suggesting that they are both more reactive to warmer, late of season temperatures. Lastly, *B. alleghaniensis* which responded to both the SOS and the EOS points towards a counter interacting trend where an early SOS decreases growth, but a later EOS increases it, which might have led this species to not respond to a longer calendar season.

Growth strategies across species may change how responsive they are. All of our species are relatively fast growing which are known to track changing conditions better than their slower growth counterparts. Indeed, while we found an overall positive trend of warmer seasons on growth, this might have changed if we used slower growing species, like oaks (*Quercus*). Additionally, we used juvenile trees which tend to be more reactive and could further explain why they grew more with warmer seasons. However, if these trees grew in nature they would have been below the canopy, competing for light and other resources and thus might not have responded as much as we observed in competition-limited conditions.

We found that provenance did not impact growth, suggesting that local adaption on growth is weak under current environmental conditions. EOS events such as budset are much more locally adapted than SOS

events such as leafout. Therefore, our findings of a weak influence of local adaptation on growth may be a consequence of our surprising result that provenance did not affect budset either (Buoniuto, unpublished). Additionally, while we have strong evidence of local adaptation of leaf phenophases, we know little about how provenances affect growth. Understanding this, requires teasing out the effects of leaf and wood phenology at the SOS and EOS.

Future carbon models and range shifts projections should consider species

Using a rarely available dataset of growth with the SOS and EOS, we showed an overall positive response from our trees to longer seasons. We did use juvenile trees and their positive response may be muted in nature where they would compete for light. Additionally, our findings suggest that the SOS and EOS asymmetrically matter to growth, and we don't fully grasp why. Thus, we highlight the importance of considering different metrics of season length and not only SOS (e.g. Dow, Wheeler2016Snow and ...). Finally, we showed strong species differences despite them being closely related—all within the same family. Species differences matter and we do not currently consider them enough in carbon model and range shifts projections.

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Supplemental material

Supplemental Methods

Table S1: Provenance coordinates and count per species and provenances out of a total of 81 individual trees sampled from the USA (in MA and NH) and Canada (in Qc).

Provenance	Longitude	Latitude	<i>A. incana</i> (<i>n</i> = 29)	<i>B. alleghaniensis</i> (<i>n</i> = 20)	<i>B. papyrifera</i> (<i>n</i> = 7)	<i>B. populifolia</i> (<i>n</i> = 25)
Harvard Forest (MA)	-72.2	42.5	7	0	4	7
White Mountains (NH)	-71.0	44.1	6	7	0	9
Dartmouth College (NH)	-70.7	44.9	8	7	2	9
St-Hippolyte (Qc)	-74.0	46.0	8	6	1	0

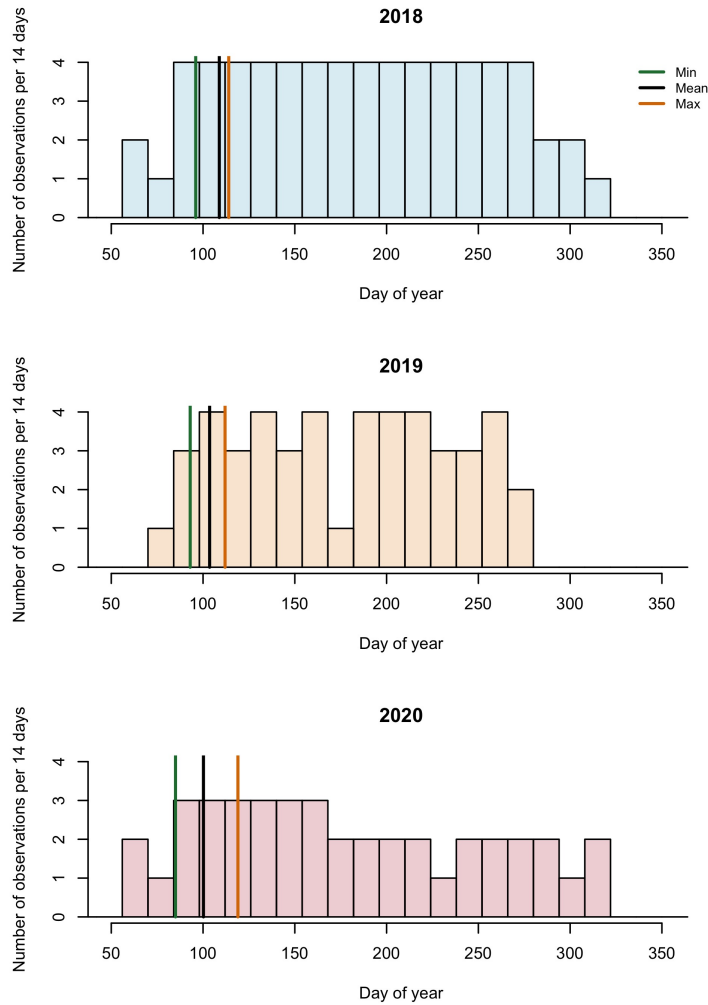


Figure S1: Leaf phenology monitoring frequency across years. We monitored leaf phenology once or twice per week for three years, though the frequency varied within and across years. Each histogram bin represents the number of observations that were made during a period of 14 days and the lines represent the earliest, the average and last recorded budburst observations. This demonstrates that across the different frequencies of observation, distances between early spring phenophases were similar across years.

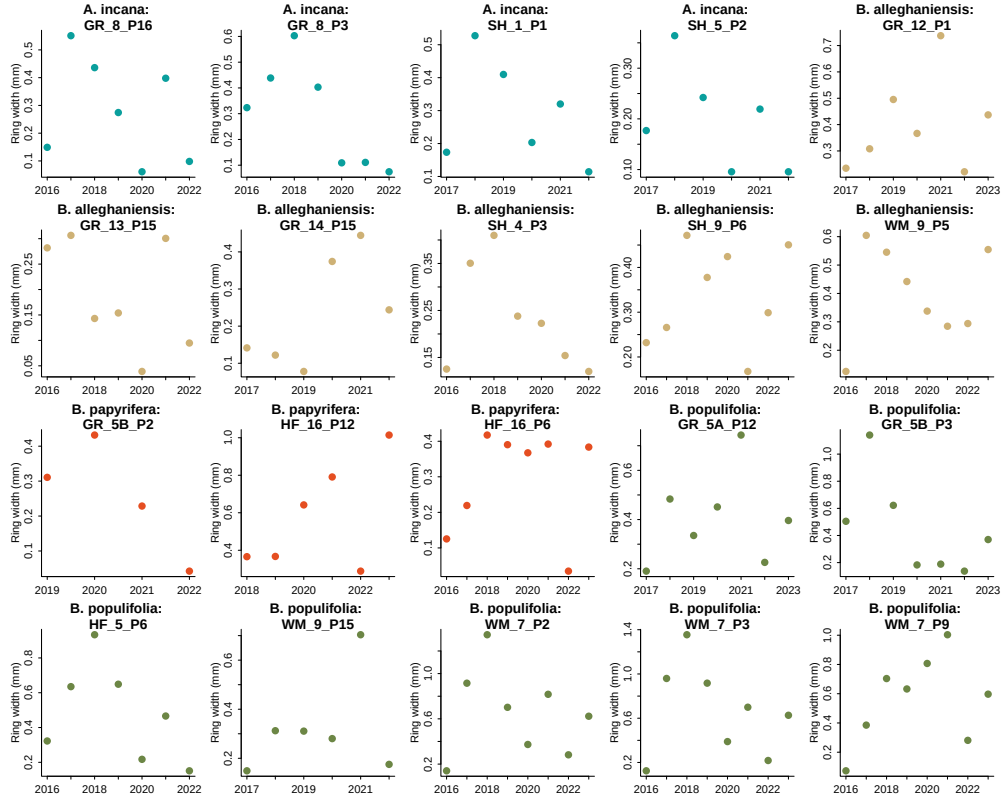


Figure S2: We show 20 randomly sampled trees from our dataset and represent the ring width (mm) as a function of year to represent the potential allometry patterns across all years we had ring width for.

Supplemental Results

Table S2: Species level slope parameters which represent ring width change ($\log(\text{mm})$), per scaled predictor (see data analyses section for more details). We report estimates as mean and 90% uncertainty intervals (in square brackets) across our four different phenological predictors (GDD: growing degree days across the growing season, GSL: growing season length, SOS: start of season and EOS: end of season).

Species	GDD	GSL	SOS	EOS
<i>A. incana</i>	0.02 [-0.01, 0.05]	0.05 [0.00, 0.10]	-0.07 [-0.14, -0.01]	-0.01 [-0.07, 0.04]
<i>B. alleghaniensis</i>	0.04 [0.00, 0.08]	0.03 [-0.03, 0.09]	0.10 [0.00, 0.20]	0.12 [0.05, 0.18]
<i>B. papyrifera</i>	0.15 [0.06, 0.23]	0.18 [0.06, 0.31]	0.05 [-0.11, 0.20]	0.21 [0.09, 0.33]
<i>B. populifolia</i>	0.07 [0.02, 0.12]	0.06 [-0.02, 0.13]	0.05 [-0.07, 0.16]	0.10 [0.02, 0.17]

Table S3: The effect of provenance on ring widths ($\log(\text{mm})$). We report these intercept estimates as mean and 90% uncertainty intervals (in square brackets) across our four different predictors (GDD: growing degree days, GSL: growing season length, SOS: start of season and EOS: end of season).

Provenance	GDD	GSL	SOS	EOS
Harvard Forest (MA)	-0.10 [-0.33, 0.07]	-0.09 [-0.35, 0.08]	-0.05 [-0.26, 0.12]	-0.09 [-0.32, 0.06]
White Mountains (NH)	0.08 [-0.09, 0.30]	0.08 [-0.10, 0.31]	0.08 [-0.07, 0.29]	0.07 [-0.08, 0.27]
Dartmouth College (NH)	-0.03 [-0.23, 0.16]	-0.04 [-0.25, 0.14]	-0.07 [-0.28, 0.09]	-0.04 [-0.22, 0.12]
St-Hippolyte (Qc)	0.04 [-0.15, 0.26]	0.03 [-0.16, 0.26]	0.02 [-0.16, 0.21]	0.04 [-0.12, 0.24]

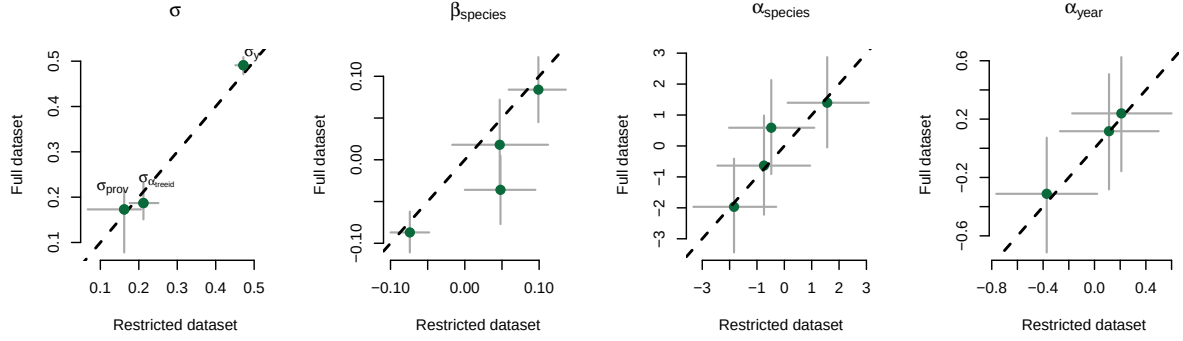
Table S4: Summary output of each parameter from our four predictors, using ring width ($\log(\text{mm})$) as the reponse variable. We report estimates as mean and 90% uncertainty intervals (in square brackets) across our four different predictors (GDD: growing degree days, GSL: growing season length, SOS: start of season and EOS: end of season). See ‘Data analyses’ in Methods section for more details.

Parameter	GDD	GSL	SOS	EOS
α	-0.56 [-4.47, 3.48]	0.11 [-4.05, 4.17]	1.10 [-2.55, 4.76]	-1.36 [-5.54, 2.87]
$\sigma_{\alpha_{treeid}}$	0.17 [0.04, 0.27]	0.18 [0.05, 0.28]	0.21 [0.10, 0.30]	0.18 [0.07, 0.28]
$\sigma_{\alpha_{prov}}$	0.17 [0.02, 0.47]	0.18 [0.02, 0.52]	0.16 [0.02, 0.45]	0.17 [0.02, 0.44]
σ_y	0.48 [0.43, 0.52]	0.48 [0.44, 0.53]	0.47 [0.43, 0.52]	0.47 [0.42, 0.52]
$\beta_{speciesA.incana}$	0.02 [-0.01, 0.05]	0.05 [0.00, 0.10]	-0.07 [-0.14, -0.01]	-0.01 [-0.07, 0.04]
$\beta_{speciesB.allegghaniensis}$	0.04 [0.00, 0.08]	0.03 [-0.03, 0.09]	0.10 [0.00, 0.20]	0.12 [0.05, 0.18]
$\beta_{speciesB.papyrifera}$	0.15 [0.06, 0.23]	0.18 [0.06, 0.31]	0.05 [-0.11, 0.20]	0.21 [0.09, 0.33]
$\beta_{speciesB.populifolia}$	0.07 [0.02, 0.12]	0.06 [-0.02, 0.13]	0.05 [-0.07, 0.16]	0.10 [0.02, 0.17]
$\alpha_{provDartmouthCollege(NH)}$	-0.03 [-0.23, 0.16]	-0.04 [-0.25, 0.14]	-0.07 [-0.28, 0.09]	-0.04 [-0.22, 0.12]
$\alpha_{provHarvardForest(MA)}$	-0.10 [-0.33, 0.07]	-0.09 [-0.35, 0.08]	-0.05 [-0.26, 0.12]	-0.09 [-0.32, 0.06]
$\alpha_{provSt-Hippolyte(Qc)}$	0.04 [-0.15, 0.26]	0.03 [-0.16, 0.26]	0.02 [-0.16, 0.21]	0.04 [-0.12, 0.24]
$\alpha_{provWhiteMountains(NH)}$	0.08 [-0.09, 0.30]	0.08 [-0.10, 0.31]	0.08 [-0.07, 0.29]	0.07 [-0.08, 0.27]
$\alpha_{year2018}$	0.18 [-0.76, 1.10]	0.22 [-0.73, 1.17]	0.21 [-0.75, 1.16]	0.23 [-0.71, 1.17]
$\alpha_{year2019}$	0.16 [-0.78, 1.08]	0.09 [-0.87, 1.04]	0.11 [-0.85, 1.06]	0.12 [-0.83, 1.05]
$\alpha_{year2020}$	-0.45 [-1.38, 0.48]	-0.36 [-1.32, 0.59]	-0.37 [-1.33, 0.59]	-0.47 [-1.41, 0.47]
$\alpha_{speciesA.incana}$	1.00 [-3.08, 5.07]	0.15 [-3.89, 4.32]	1.57 [-1.99, 5.15]	3.12 [-1.35, 7.53]
$\alpha_{speciesB.allegghaniensis}$	0.15 [-3.97, 4.24]	0.38 [-3.72, 4.63]	-1.84 [-5.53, 1.75]	-1.80 [-6.37, 2.65]
$\alpha_{speciesB.papyrifera}$	-4.04 [-8.95, 0.81]	-2.67 [-7.20, 1.95]	-0.74 [-4.90, 3.44]	-5.51 [-11.12, 0.08]
$\alpha_{speciesB.populifolia}$	-0.71 [-4.93, 3.38]	0.24 [-3.98, 4.52]	-0.48 [-4.34, 3.21]	-0.83 [-5.53, 3.95]

Table S5: Summary output of each parameter from our four predictors, using basal area increment ($\log(\text{mm}^2)$) as the reponse variable. We report estimates as mean and 90% uncertainty intervals (in square brackets) across our four different predictors (GDD: growing degree days, GSL: growing season length, SOS: start of season and EOS: end of season). See data analyses section for more details.

Parameter	Estimate
α	0.62 [-4.52, 5.84]
$\sigma_{\alpha_{treeid}}$	0.52 [0.41, 0.64]
$\sigma_{\alpha_{prov}}$	0.27 [0.03, 0.73]
σ_y	0.63 [0.57, 0.70]
$\beta_{speciesA.incana}$	0.11 [-0.03, 0.25]
$\beta_{speciesB.allegghaniensis}$	0.20 [0.02, 0.36]
$\beta_{speciesB.papyrifera}$	0.92 [0.49, 1.34]
$\beta_{speciesB.populifolia}$	0.41 [0.20, 0.61]
$\alpha_{siteDartmouthCollege(NH)}$	-0.11 [-0.47, 0.17]
$\alpha_{siteHarvardForest(MA)}$	-0.09 [-0.45, 0.19]
$\alpha_{siteSt-Hippolyte(Qc)}$	0.06 [-0.23, 0.42]
$\alpha_{siteWhiteMountains(NH)}$	0.15 [-0.11, 0.52]
$\alpha_{year2018}$	-0.36 [-1.32, 0.61]
$\alpha_{year2019}$	0.33 [-0.65, 1.32]
$\alpha_{year2020}$	-0.04 [-1.01, 0.94]
$\alpha_{speciesA.incana}$	3.23 [-2.25, 8.55]
$\alpha_{speciesB.allegghaniensis}$	2.09 [-3.40, 7.54]
$\alpha_{speciesB.papyrifera}$	-7.59 [-14.84, -0.29]
$\alpha_{speciesB.populifolia}$	-0.07 [-5.98, 5.57]

(a) Start of season (SOS)



(b) End of season (EOS)

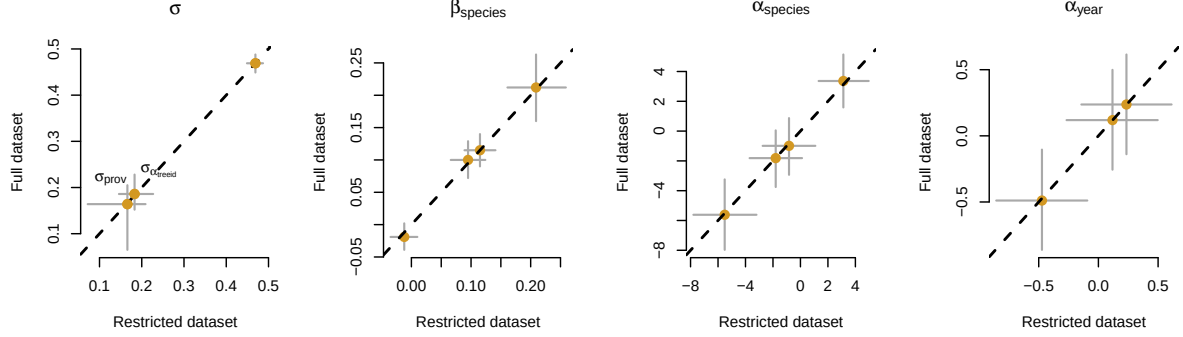


Figure S3: Full vs most restricted datasets for the model with start of season (SOS; a) and end of season (EOS; b) as the predictor. Each panel represent the different parameters used to fit the models. $\alpha_{species}$ and α_{year} represent the ring width (log(mm)) for species and year, respectively. $\beta_{species}$ represent the change in ring width (log(mm)) per scaled predictor for each species (see data analyses section for more details).

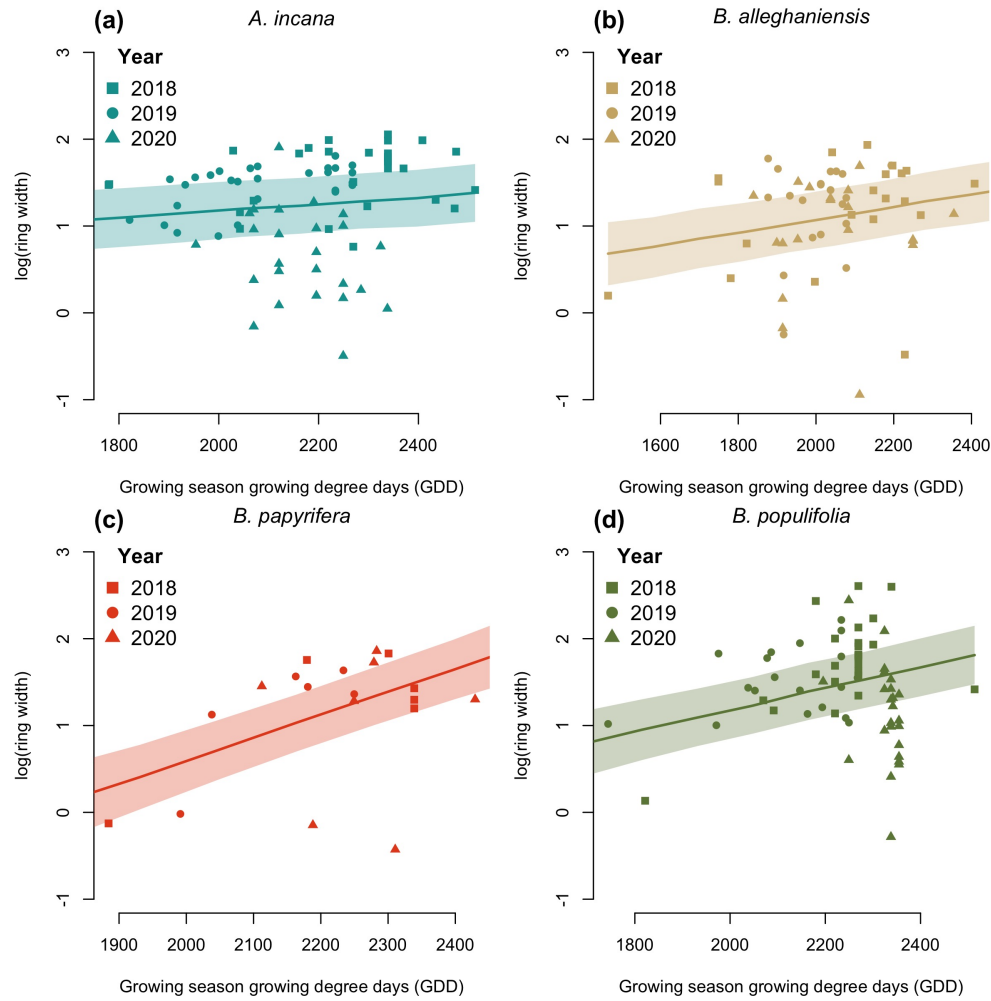


Figure S4: Ring width (log(mm)) trends in response to thermal season (growing degree days; GDD). The plots are the reconstructed species estimates posterior distribution with error. The lines represent the mean of the posterior distribution and the shaded area, the 50% UI. The dots are the empirical data shaped by year.

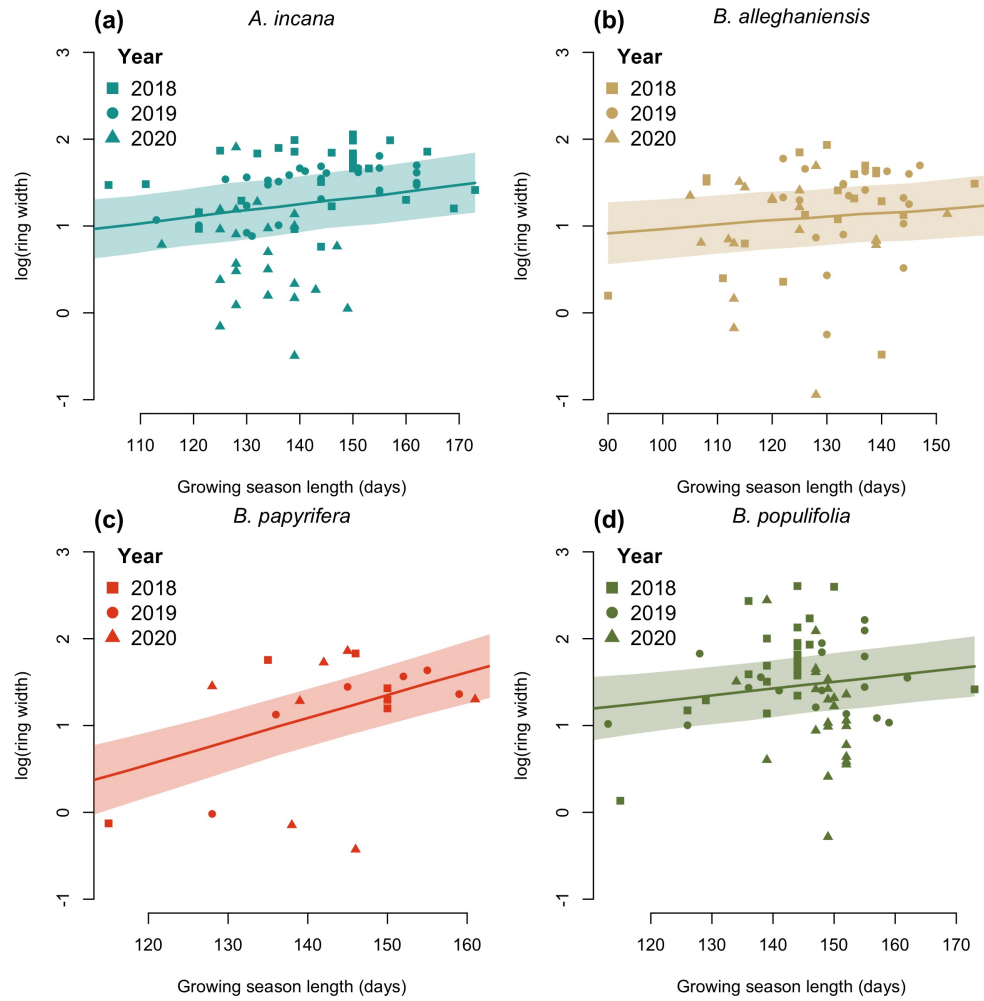


Figure S5: Ring width trends ($\log(\text{mm})$) in response to calendar season (growing season length; GSL). The plots are the reconstructed species estimates posterior distribution with error. The lines represent the mean of the posterior distribution and the shaded area, the interquantile range (IQR). The dots are the empirical data shaped by year.

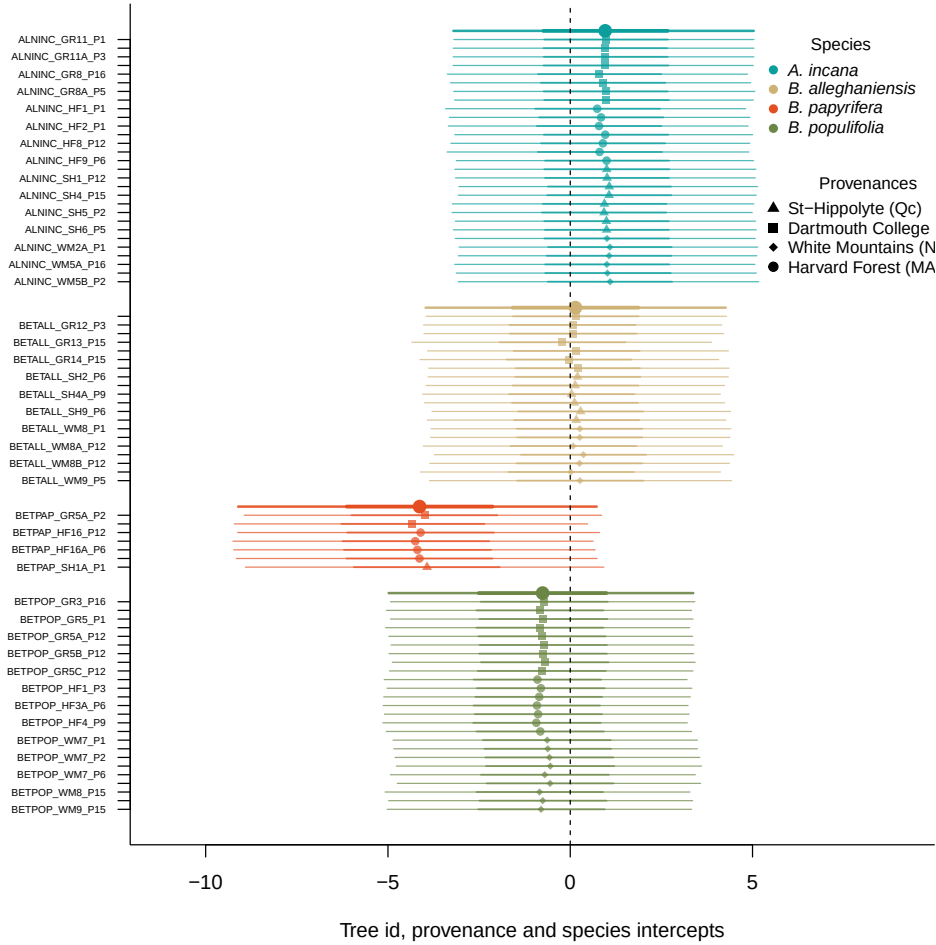


Figure S6: Ring width (log(mm)) deviations from the grand mean for grouping factor of the GDD model. The different tree id values represent the combined intercepts of tree id, provenance, species and averaged year intercepts. The larger dots and lines represent the species intercepts which are the species level estimates averaged across all of their tree ids. The dots are the mean of the posterior distribution and the thick and thin lines, the 50 and 90% UI.

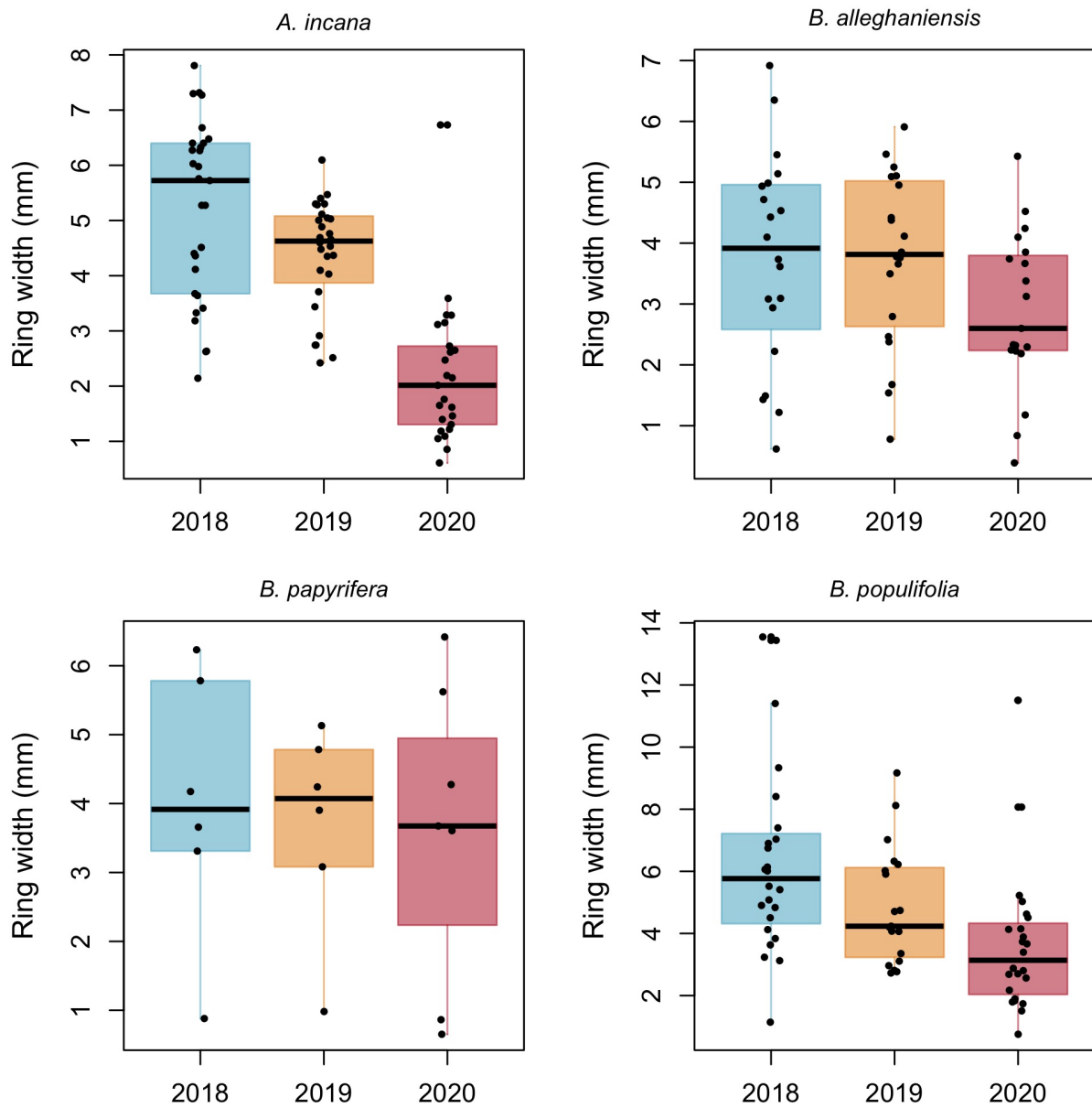


Figure S7: Boxplot representing the empirical data of our ring widths (mm) faceted by species. The dots represent the raw data, the line is the mean and the box depicts the interquartile range (IQR).

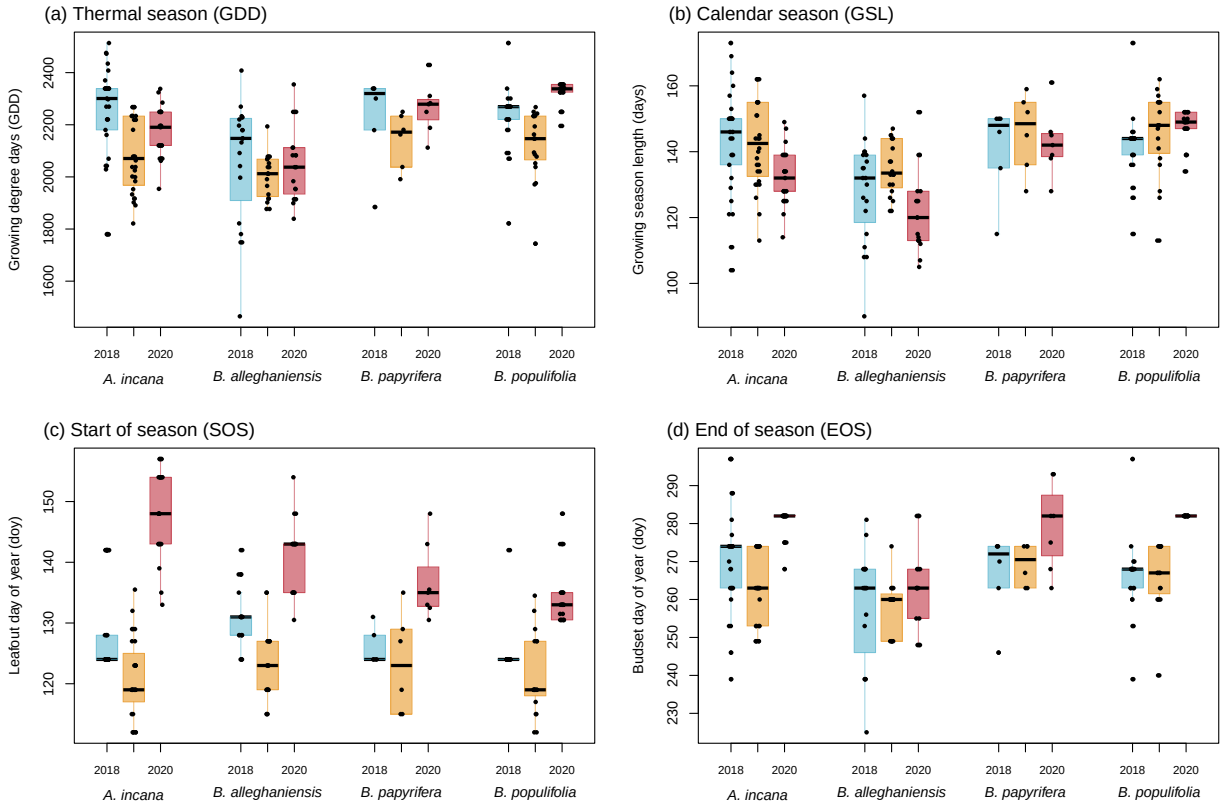


Figure S8: Boxplot representing the empirical data of all out predictors clustered by species, and for each year. The dots represent the raw data, the line is the mean and the box depicts the interquartile range (IQR).

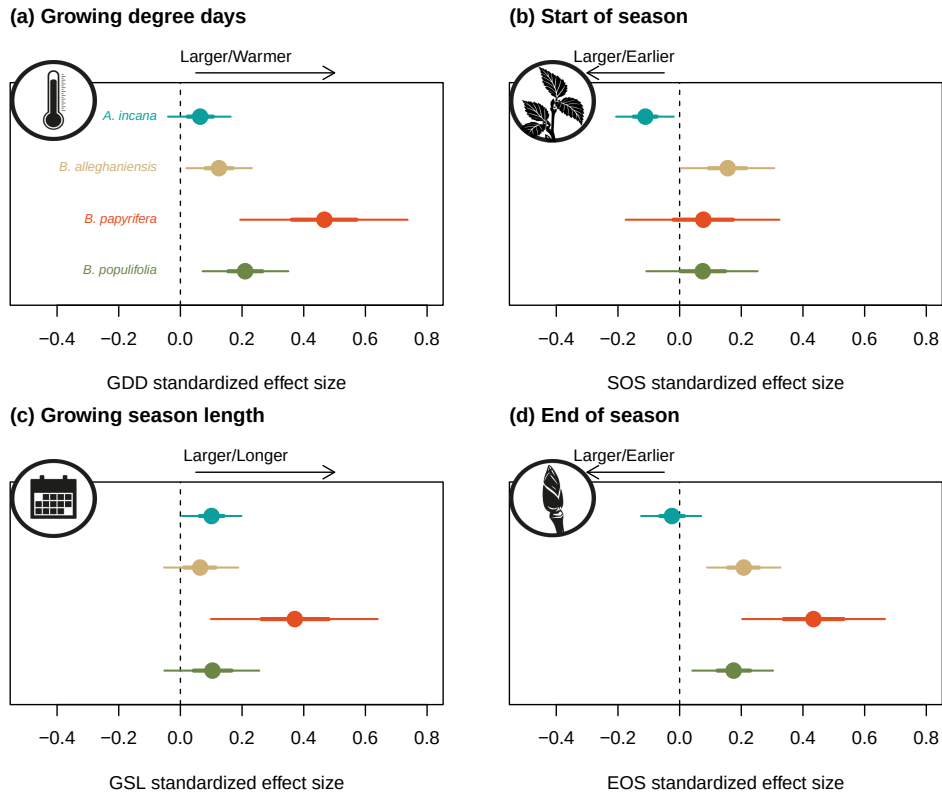


Figure S9: Effect size of each predictors across our four species. We depict ring width ($\log(\text{mm})$) change per scaled (z -scored; see data analyses section for more details) predictor for each species. We report estimates as mean and 90% uncertainty intervals (in square brackets) across our four different predictors (GDD: growing degree days, GSL: growing season length, SOS: start of season and EOS: end of season).